



dropped a spot to let the youngster bat in his preferred position.

Tilak repaid that faith in style. "Surya bhai's best knocks have come at No. 4, so I asked if I could try at three. I told him, 'You've made hundreds there, now let me show what I can do,'" he had told this publication.

Tilak was effusive in his praise for head coach Gautam Gambhir and Suryakumar, also his IPL teammate at Mumbai Indians. "Gautam sir supports every player and gives us confidence. And when Surya says that even if you get out for zero, we'll still back you — that message lifts your morale instantly. Both always tell us to express ourselves, and that's a huge message."

Beyond the T20 label

Tilak is determined not to be boxed in as a T20 specialist. "I'm good, but I want to be a complete all-format player. For me, Test cricket is the ultimate challenge. I know it won't be easy, but I'm working really hard to get there."

The Indian dressing room, he said, makes that journey easier. "The

atmosphere and bonding are excellent. You never feel out of place. Everyone, including the support staff, is so good."

A summer stint with Hampshire further underlined Tilak's growing maturity, as he amassed 358 runs in four County Championship matches at an average just shy of 60, including two centuries and a fifty. The 22-year-old left-hander blended restraint with authority, batting with a calm assurance that spoke of an evolving all-format temperament.

"Playing County cricket had a big positive impact. I thought I might get an India-A call after that, but I'm happy with the backing I've got so far. Switching between red and white ball doesn't bother me — if anything, it's made me more positive and aggressive.

"Succeeding in different conditions and on tough tracks shows I'm ready for bigger opportunities. Mentally and physically, I feel ready to be an all-format player. I rarely miss domestic First-Class matches when available — domestic cricket is a huge platform to refine your game."

Tilak's rise stems from a steady

Guided growth: Rohit Sharma's quiet counsel, Tilak Varma's eager ear — a passing of wisdom that mirrors Indian cricket's changing guard.

EMMANUEL YOGINI

progression through Under-16, U-19 and Ranji Trophy cricket. "Even if there's no First-Class game, I'll still play a club match. I just can't stay away from cricket." Tilak first flickered on the radar at a domestic U-16 tournament in 2018, where he plundered 960 runs for Hyderabad — a number so audacious it demanded attention. That same season, barely 16, he was fast-tracked into the Ranji Trophy side, making his First-Class debut for Hyderabad. The following year, he checked off the remaining boxes of the domestic circuit, featuring in both the Syed Mushtaq Ali and Vijay Hazare trophies. By the time he topped the scoring charts in a quadrangular U-19 series involving South Africa, Zimbabwe and New Zealand to seal his spot in India's 2020 U-19 World Cup squad, Tilak had already lived a small career before turning eighteen — each